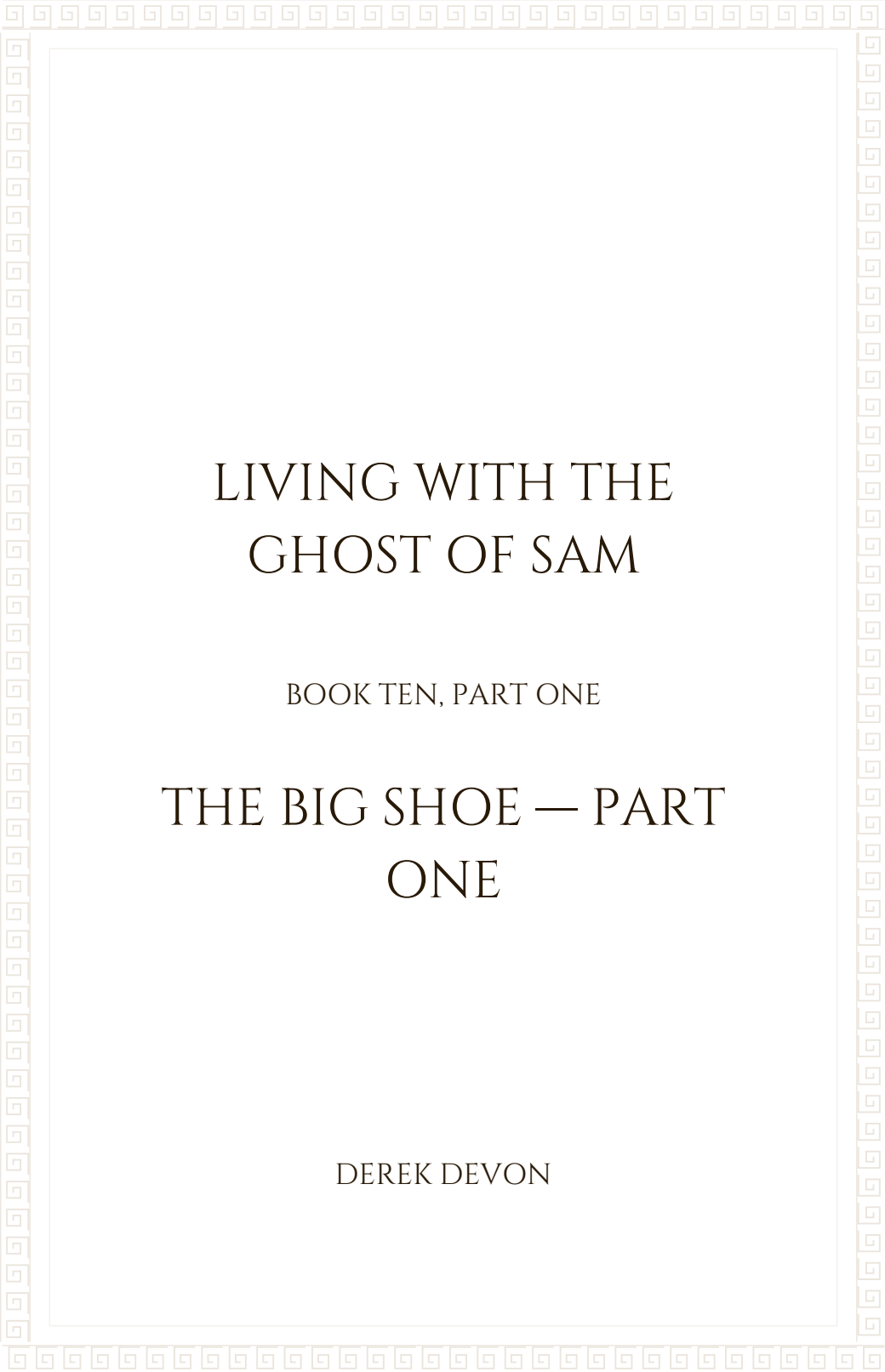




LIVING WITH THE GHOST OF SAM

BOOK TEN, PART ONE

THE BIG SHOE — PART ONE

DEREK DEVON

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To Derek Devon,

without whom none of this would have been possible, and with whom all of it took considerably longer than promised. A man of rare vision — most of it requiring reading glasses.

He named the hero after himself, dedicated the final book to himself, and sees no problem with either. The author would like to thank the author, who was there for him through every deadline he personally missed.

Take a bow, Derek. Somebody had to.

THE LIVING WITH THE GHOST OF SAM SERIES

Book One — Living With the Ghost of Sam

Book Two — Night Moves

Book Three — Two Out of Three Ain't Bad

Book Four — Last Laugh

Book Five — Digital Inheritance

Book Six — Missing

Book Seven — Command Performance

Book Eight — The Strange Emergence of Ms. Peel

Book Nine — Five Comedians Walk into a Bar

Book Ten — The Big Shoe, Parts One & Two



CHAPTER ONE

THE RADIO KNOWS YOUR NAME

You never know when life's gonna hit you with the punchline. Sometimes it winds up for twenty-four hours, like one of those TV shows with the ticking clock and the guy who never sleeps. Twenty-four hours. Who's got that kind of time? Not you, pal. Not me either — and I'm dead, I've got nothing BUT time. So here's what we're gonna do. We're gonna tell this one fast. And if the clock starts running long... well. Let's just say I know a guy. OH OH OHHHH.

The church basement had never been consecrated for anything like this.

Robed figures moved through the darkness arranging ancient symbols on the stone floor, and the only light in the room came from dozens of modified Oculus headsets, each one pulsing blue in perfect synchronization — a congregation of small electronic heartbeats, all keeping the same impossible rhythm.

Rebecca moved through the shadows, inspecting the work. Behind her, Marina and Chad sat motionless in ornate chairs, already wearing their headsets. Their skin had taken on an unnatural grey tone, the color of people who had been left out of their own lives.

Rebecca paused beside Chad and touched his face with something almost like tenderness.

"Soon, grandfather. After all these years..."

A council member approached carrying what appeared to be an architectural drawing. It wasn't. Up close, it was a schematic that had no business existing — Mayan symbols braided through advanced technology, two languages separated by millennia agreeing on a single design.

"The quantum harmonics are aligning," the council member said. "It's happening just as the prophecy said."

Through a stained glass window in the church tower, the mansion sat on its distant hill. A single light burned in the widow's walk, patient as an unblinking eye.

"And the Kinisons?" Rebecca asked.

Mel emerged from the shadows, the blue cube pulsing in her hands. "Everything's ready, mother, except my trip to Ravencrest later. By sunset, the mansion's consciousness will be merged with ours."



A hundred and some miles away, Charles Weber's Tesla truck cut through morning fog, and Charles was doing what Charles always did on a long drive: letting Sirius XM's POTUS channel and the Michael Smerconish show keep him company.

"I know, TC, that we talked about this just yesterday," the speakers said, "but you have to admit that Canada has taken just as radical a position as President Trump by signing onto the new Global Free Trade Alliance Agreement, with over fifteen countries all participating, and America, I guess, getting its wish of becoming truly nationally isolated."

"But Michael, I don't want to have to give up my Montreal maple syrup or my wonderful Canadian poutine."

"Well, TC, you may just have to give in to replacing poutine with Dalessandro's Philly steak, extra drippy. But enough about

politics — let's talk about the poll question of the day. Should Charles Weber try to steal Derek's mansion's AI technology for himself?"

Charles's hand found the volume on the steering wheel before his brain had finished processing the sentence.

"Currently the poll numbers are around sixty-forty," the speakers continued cheerfully, "but I think we will see that number shift further to ninety-ten by the end of Charles's drive."

"Now Michael, we both know that Charles has been having some personality issues of late, and unless he is able to find the right balance, it could turn out really bad for him."

Charles chuckled. It was a good chuckle. It almost sounded convincing. "Okay, who put you up to this elaborate trick. Very funny."

"Oh hey, it's Charles! You know, Charles, it's a lightning round, so what is the one thing you want to say?"

"You can hear me?"

"Yes, Charles, we can hear you just fine. Dan, can we hear Charles just fine? Yes, Michael, he is coming through perfectly."

"Did I call into the show by accident?"

"No, Charles. You're having another one of your psychotic breakdowns. Just like the hospital."

Charles reached over, tapped the audio button, and hit the close option with a finality he did not feel. "Goodbye."

Michael Smerconish appeared on the Tesla's center display, looking directly at him. "Nope, still here, Charles. In fact, we are all here" — and TC's and Dan's faces bloomed onto the screen beside him, three broadcast professionals regarding him with the warm interest of men watching a poll number move. "Nothing like a good

mingle, is it, Charles?"

Charles spotted a gas station up ahead, pulled in, parked, turned off the truck, and got out. Then, on the oil-stained concrete of a highway gas station, one of marketing's great CEOs began to jump up and down and wave his arms in something that was technically a jumping jack the way a fall down the stairs is technically a descent.

"Focus, Charles, focus... breathe in and out... one... two... three..."

Above him, the morning fog burned slowly away, and somewhere far ahead, a town by the ocean was setting the table for him.

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Somewhere outside the story, a clock the size of a television network read 24:00:00. Sam looked at it, looked at you, and shook his head. Twenty-four hours. For THIS? He rolled up one sleeve.

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CHAPTER TWO

HOW TO WEAPONIZE A HUMMINGBIRD

Smithers was methodically arranging breakfast items when Derek wandered into the kitchen, and through the window behind him, something impossible was hovering near the flowers.

"That's one big hummingbird," Derek said.

"Ah yes. The Mark 7 Surveillance Unit. Mr. Rhodes had quite the sense of humor with his designs."

The hummingbird chose that moment to pivot, revealing itself as a sophisticated drone wearing a bird costume. Inside a cabinet, a small hidden screen carried its camera feed — and on that feed, reflected where no reflection should be, was Rodney Dangerfield.

"I tell ya, this surveillance gig gets no respect! Yesterday I got attacked by a real hummingbird — thought I was moving in on his territory!"

"OH OH OHHHH!" Sam's voice rang from everywhere and nowhere. "At least you didn't get dive-bombed by an eagle like the Mark 3!"

The cabinet swung wider to reveal an entire aviary and menagerie of nature-themed drones: squirrels, owls, even a raccoon whose eyes were suspiciously high-tech.

"So when you said you had eyes everywhere..." Derek said.

"Master Kinison, in this house, even the garden gnomes file reports."

Out in the garden, as if taking attendance, a gnome's eyes glowed briefly blue.



Down in the basement lab, on the little stage designated 1D, Derek finished a run of Sam's material and pulled back from the invisible microphone to face his audience of three: Nancy, Larry, and Smithers, seated in a row like the world's strangest tenure committee.

"So, how was that?"

"Larry, it's okay," Nancy said, patting the air in Larry's direction. "Yes, it's a bit scary, but that was Sam's shtick. Smithers, you do not have to sit and endure this if you have other things to do. Well — I must confess I prefer a good Sarah Silverman set, but you did nail it. I was just a bit shocked you didn't drop to the floor and do his necrophilia routine." She gave Derek a cute smile that took most of the sting out of the word *necrophilia*, which is not a small job for a smile.

"Well, now that you mention it, Miss Nancy," Smithers said, rising, "I should scrub the oven out and give the pantry a thorough re-organization." He exited the lab with the unhurried speed of a man escaping a burning building with his dignity intact.

"I would have thought, Smithers, with all the time you spent here, you would have something a little bit more original," Derek called after him.

Smithers's voice floated back through the doorway. "Like your set, Master Kinison."

Larry made a sound that was almost a laugh and then thought better of it.



Across town, the Township Council chambers were being dressed for a show. A dozen people moved among the seats, and on every seat rested an Oculus headset.

"Everyone double-check that each headset is fully charged and there is one per seat," a council member directed. "Also, I want you to make sure each seat is properly plugged into the floor jacks."

Up in the councillors' balcony, Rebecca stood surveying the work below. She did not turn when a figure in a hoodie slipped into the balcony and crossed to her — and anyone watching from behind that hooded figure would have seen only posture and purpose, nothing of a face.

"So is everything in place?" Rebecca asked.

"Not yet. I have to sneak over to the mansion and make the final connection."

"I assume you are going through the tunnel entrance in the woods?"

"Yes. I will take the electric dirt bike and should be back in an hour."

"The Kinisons are not stupid people, and you had better be prepared for Smithers as well. I think you should take one other person with you to watch your back."

"I always carry great-granddad's immobilizer device."

"That is a weapon of last resort, young lady. You know that will permanently scramble a person's mind."

"You're not getting soft on me, are you, mother!"

"Mel, just don't do something you will regret. Or worse — get caught and ruin everything!"



Charles's truck exited the highway past a road sign reading OCEANVIEW 145 MILES, and Charles was working his program.

"Okay, Charles, hold it together, big guy. You are the master of yourself... You are the master of yourself..."

His expression changed the way weather changes.

"My grandfather always said, 'Don't watch your money; watch your health,'" said Charles's mouth, in the unmistakable Borscht Belt cadence of Jackie Mason. "So one day, while I was watching my health, someone stole my money. It was my grandfather."

Charles snapped back like a rubber band. "I am the master of me. I am the master of ME. I am—"

The truck's display lit with an incoming call. The name said MEL.

"Who is this?"

"Hi Charles, this is Mel, and don't freak out — you don't know me yet, but I am going to meet you at the Kinison performance tonight."

"How did you get my number? How do you know I was going?"

"Oh, let's say your buddy PEEWEE told me. In fact, I told PEEWEE to give you a visit. I need you to go to the mansion for 5 p.m. exactly. See you soon, Charles!"

The call ended. Charles's face had moved past surprise into the suburbs of panic. "I am the master of me... I am the master of me... I am the—"

"—master of me!" his own mouth finished, in a voice that giggled at its own gears. "What a fun-looking truck, Charles... I feel a movie theatre moment coming on... get it, Charles?" And Charles/PEEWEE put the Tesla in auto-drive and reached for his zipper while the truck, mercifully uninterested, drove on.

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Back in Lab 1D, Larry was pointing at the base of the microphone. "See this tiny switch-looking thing right here, Mr. K?"

"When will I know when I need to flip it?"

"I have mounted a small light to the microphone stand — right there. When it turns red, that is your signal. AISAM will be in control of that."

Nancy, who had brought her yoga mat down to the lab and was flowing through her moves in the corner, spoke without breaking form. "Derek, I think you need to run through the last ten minutes. I think the first ten minutes is perfect, but you look a little off for the second half."

In the mirror near the stage, the reflection of the comedian Gallagher appeared, mustache first.

"I suggest that the young lady with the beautiful booty use my Sledge-O-Matic to close the show."

"Gallagher, I thought we had a talk about you talking about my booty. That is exclusively Mr. K's domain."

"OK, Mom, SORRY... holy ruining a great bit... I will go see Smithers to see if he has any old watermelons he wants to get rid of."

"I warned you, babe, about working out in the mansion," Derek said.

"You're right... I think I will go for a run shortly."

"And miss my practice session."

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CHAPTER THREE

TAINTED LOVE AND OTHER TRAFFIC HAZARDS

The view from the Tesla's back seat, had anyone been sitting there, would have shown Charles's face scrunched and shifting, his body rocking back and forth like a man arguing with his own upholstery.

As Charles slipped fully into the PEEWEE persona, the truck's sound system erupted with The Dickies' version of the "Pee-wee's Big Adventure" theme, followed — at awkwardly, criminally high volume — by Ray Stevens' "The Streak."

"It's just like the Alamo theater all over again!" Charles/PEEWEE giggled maniacally, working his zipper. "Oh, Miss Yvonne... are you bad, Miss Yvonne... Do you want to spank PEEWEE, Miss Yvonne..."

The music cut abruptly to Soft Cell's "Tainted Love" as Charles briefly clawed his way back to the surface of himself.

Then lost his grip again.



Down in the church basement, no one was laughing. Chad and Marina sat quietly in two chairs against the wall, Oculus headsets over their eyes, dressed in white clothing with dark red capes — a matched set of something that used to be people, waiting to be unwrapped.



In the mansion kitchen, Smithers was puttering, and for the first time in living memory, puttering nervously.

"Hey Smithers, I think I have finally nailed the entire act," Derek said, fiddling with the ancient coffee machine. "I plan to do one last full run-through, and then we should be ready for the Big Shoe."

"Master Kinison, let me help you with that. The old girl can be a bit temperamental on days like today. Seems the entire mansion is a bit out of sorts today."

Derek stepped back and surrendered the machine. "You know, Smithers, we never did get a chance to have that sit-down and chat all about you. I think I have a good read on Larry and Earl. Betty and old Pete are exactly what you see. But you, my wise old friend — and I use *old* in a purely endearing sense — I know very little about, other than you seem to be exceptionally light on your feet."

"Well, Master Kinison," Smithers said, loading coffee into the old-fashioned, high-tech device, "I will tell you I have always been a fan of Gene Kelly. But I am what you see. Simple, a good listener, and most of all, loyal."

In the kitchen's main mirror, Chris Farley appeared, sweaty and out of breath. "Did I hear *light on their feet*? Watch this." He launched into a series of Gene Kelly-like dance moves that landed somewhere closer to a medical event.

"Chris, go towel off, big guy." Derek turned back to his butler. "Yeah, I know all that stuff. I am talking about the inner Smithers. The Smithers that might let his hair down and grab a cold pint of Guinness at a pub, or maybe head into the forest to do a little trout fishing. You know — the Smithers I don't get to see."

"Well, Master Kinison, I will give you my word that the next time I head into a pub to grab a pint of Guinness, or decide to grab my fishing gear and venture into the woods for a trout-catching outing, I will ask if you wish to join me."

Don Rickles appeared in the mirror. "I haven't seen anyone that tight since Phyllis Diller's last facelift."

"Come on, Don, I thought we agreed you would lay off the women this week."

"You really know how to take a guy out at the knees, kid... maybe a job with the mob was your true calling." Rickles put his head down and walked out of view, sulking with the craftsmanship of a man who had spent sixty years perfecting the exit.

"Sorry, Smithers. Mrs. H and I have been trying to teach the kids how to be nicer to one another. We understand they had thirty-plus years stuck together, but this is 2025 and maybe time to change their ways."

"Well, Master Kinison, I think you may have better luck grabbing a pint with me, or going fishing with me, than changing their ways."

"There's the loose Smithers I was looking for."

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CHAPTER FOUR

ZERO DEVIATION

"God damn it. What the hell just happened. Gee-zus, I don't have another pair of pants this color with me." Charles grabbed a fistful of fast-food napkins and went to work on his trousers with the grim focus of a man auditing his own dignity.

Then his body shifted, and the uninvited guest was back.

"Oh, Miss Yvonne... oh, Miss Yvonne, that was fab-u-lous. Although after thirty-plus years, I would have expected a BIGGER BANG..."

"What the— You are the master of yourself... you are the master of yourself... you are the master—"

"I think the word you're looking for sounds like *debater*," Charles/PEEWEE offered, and followed it with the famous laugh, the one that sounded like a woodpecker discovering irony.



The screen went black, in the way a story sometimes does, and there was Sam, standing beside the giant countdown clock. He looked at it — 24-and-change to go — looked over his shoulder like a man checking for the network censor, and calmly removed four entire hours. He smiled at you. He faded.



In the church altar chamber, preparations had reached the stage where the word "ritual" stops being a metaphor. Symbols. Wiring. Candles that were actually conduits.

"Make sure everything is exact; we cannot afford a single mistake," Rebecca said. "This is a ONE CHANCE to get it right event."

A large male in a robe and mask looked up from his work. "I have everything wired exactly as Mel requested, but I am a bit concerned that the amount of energy that will be drawn from the antenna may cause a fire inside the conduit, and that will start a fire in the main hall."

"If my daughter is okay with it, then just do it. We can deal with any unplanned issues should they happen, but I want everything exactly as set out in the instruction manual. Zero deviation."

A young lady in normal clothes appeared at the doorway, looking like the only person in the building still on the payroll of the twenty-first century. "Ma'am, I have a Chief Patterson in the church office asking for you again. How do you want me to handle it?"

"I will deal with him. Go to the basement and get Marina and Chad and bring them to the office. Make sure they are properly configured. In fact, make sure Tram is the one to do that."



At 1:30 in the afternoon, Derek sat at the kitchen island with a coffee and a salad, watching Smithers work.

"So, Smithers, do you think we will be successful today?"

Smithers stopped. He actually appeared to ponder. "I think I would prefer to view it more as achieving our goals than to frame it with *success* — which, by its very nature, sets up the other option as failure."

"I guess I still have a little of the corporate jargon still occupying part of my brain. But let's use your view, Smithers. It sounds more dignified."

Nancy appeared in the kitchen doorway in her running gear. "Hey Smithers. Hey Sammy — I am going for a run. I will be back in an hour and can help you pack everything up for the show. We will need to take both cars, I will assume. Any idea when Charles is arriving?"

"I tried his phone just before I came in to bother Smithers and got no answer," Derek said. "I would have thought he would be here by now. I don't think he was planning on going right to the show."

"Honey, if we finally close on this place, we should look into getting a hot tub."

"Miss Nancy," Smithers said, "there is a 'hot pool' in the back of the solarium in the East Wing that may meet your needs. I believe Mr. Leland has it working. The plants rather do well with the steam that comes off it."

"A solarium? A hot pool? What else don't we know, Smithers?"

"You guys can discuss that while I go for a run," Nancy said, "and honey — we can check out the hot pool when I get back."

She headed out through the hallway toward the service entrance, past two large mirrors, and in those mirrors, a cluster of the mansion's kids gathered to watch her go by, every last one of them checking out her backside with a creepy grin — thirty years of dressing-room manners dying very, very hard.



Behind the church, at ten minutes to two, Mel pulled a cover off the electric dirt bike and double-checked her backpack. A second body emerged from the door.

"You will ride on the back, and make sure you don't go grabbing the merchandise. I have seen how you look at me, brother. There's a strap on the seat you can hang on with. Here — you better wear the knapsack so you can fit on the seat better."

The passenger was thirtyish, male, maybe a hundred and seventy pounds and five-ten. He put on the knapsack, then his helmet, then carefully mounted the bike behind her. The moment his hand found the seat strap, Mel took off, very nearly making the whole trip alone.

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Charles sat in the driver's seat of the parked Tesla, wearing his Oculus headset, speaking to no one visible.

"I understand completely. Do you need me to do anything else?"

A pause.

"I will comply."

He went motionless as the truck resumed driving itself, and on the dash display, faint as a watermark, another face watched Charles and typed on a keyboard.

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From high above — from the vantage of, say, a bird that files reports — Nancy could be seen jogging along the dirt trail that ran from the mansion toward town, the same trail Linda-slash-Rebecca had walked them down a couple of weeks ago on the way to the Town Council.

She spotted what she thought was a deer to her left and detoured off the path, through the long grass, to a wooden pasture fence. A mother and two offspring picked their way through the tall grass beyond it, and Nancy stood a moment and let herself admire them, because some things are still allowed to just be nice.

Her right shoelace had come loose. She knelt to tie it.

That was when she heard something on the path — and when she poked her head up, she saw two people on an electric dirt bike coming from the direction of town. As they closed, her eyes

narrowed on the driver's build, the posture, the hood.

Acid Burn, she thought.

She lowered herself into the long grass. The bike passed. She counted to safe, got up, hurried back to the dirt road, and started running after it as fast as her legs would take her.

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Sam again. He glanced at the clock — still fat with hours — sighed the sigh of a professional watching an amateur pace a set, and shaved off another three hours and fifteen minutes. Thumbs up to you personally. Gone.

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CHAPTER FIVE

THE FOYER HAS A NEW RESIDENT

"Thanks for the coffee and salad, Smithers. My body appreciates some healthy food. I think I will head over to the East Wing and check out the solarium in detail."

"Very good, Master Kinison. I will let Miss Nancy know when she gets back, as she usually stops by here and grabs a bottle of her favourite water."

"Yeah, I know. She is a bit of a water snob."

Derek left the kitchen and headed through the central foyer for the East Wing hallway doors — and stopped. Looking at him from the big foyer mirror, for the first time ever, was PEEWEE Herman.

"Aren't you PEEWEE Herman?"

"That's my name. Don't wear it out."

"Well, welcome, PEEWEE, to the mansion. I was not aware that you had been here before for a show back in the day."

"Well, Mr. Big Shot, we had our wrap party here for both *Pee-wee's Big Adventure* and *Big Top Pee-wee*, so there. I know this place better than you ever will." PEEWEE stuck out his tongue at Derek, jumped, and ran out of view.

"I don't see Sam hanging with PEEWEE," Derek said to himself. "Must have been when Sam was making *Back to School*, or touring."

He continued through the doorway and down the East Wing hall, and did not see the foyer mirror hold its emptiness a beat too long, the way a room does when it's keeping something to itself.



CHAPTER SIX

SEVEN MINUTES

At 2:15, Nancy crested a hill in time to see the dirt bike leave the path and slip into the woods that wrapped most of the mansion property. She settled back into her running pace and made for the spot where it had vanished.

Deeper in, the bike whined along a barely visible trail — deer-made, human-borrowed — until Mel brought it to a stop.

"Okay, we're here. Get your ass off and hand me the knapsack."

The passenger dismounted and handed it over. Mel pulled her helmet off, hung it on the handlebar, and walked straight into a clump of bushes that turned out to be furniture: at its center sat a metal hatch structure, squat and patient as a secret.

"Do you want me to stay here or follow you in?"

"I want you to follow me in, and your only job is to make sure no one sees us. Got it?"

"Yes, ma'am."

"You can refer to *mother* as ma'am. You call me Miss Blackwood."

"Yes, Miss Blackwood," he said — and gave her the middle finger the moment her back was turned, which was the most honest communication between them all day.

The hatch wore a combination lock. Mel bent, entered a code, and a light flicked from green to red as she swung the door fully open onto a narrow set of stairs leading down.

"We have at best five minutes before someone will notice the hatch light shows it's open. And another five minutes before they

get here to check it out. That gives us seven minutes to get in and out and be gone before they get here."

They descended, leaving the hatch open behind them.

The woods held still for a moment. Then Nancy came into view along the faint trail, breathing hard, reading the ground.

"What the hell is this, and what the hell are you up to," she murmured, scanning for direction — and found it: one faint, large footprint aimed at the bushes. Then the metal hatch lid, standing open like a dare.

She stared at it for a long fifteen seconds, doing the math every sensible person does before doing the un-sensible thing anyway. Then she went back to the dirt bike, found the key, pulled it, and tucked it into the waistband of her jogging pants.

She returned to the hatch and started down into the dark without a light — and discovered she didn't need one. The blue glow of fiber optic cables lit the stairs like the world's most ominous nightlight.



The tunnel carried voices ahead of it.

"Hold this for me and don't move. Keep a lookout for anything that looks suspicious or out of place."

"Yes, Miss Blackwood."

"And keep your voice down. These walls can hear."

"What are you actually trying to do down here?" — a whisper now.

"Just keep watch and don't say anything unless you see something. Understood?"

"Yes, ma'am. I mean — yes, Miss Blackwood."

Nancy had crept close enough to make out the two silhouettes, and the pieces snapped together in the dark.

"Miss Blackwood, is it," she breathed, barely a sound at all. "Now it is all starting to make some sense. Rebecca has a daughter that goes by the name Acid Burn... as in Acid *Blackwood*..."

She was still inching closer to their position when a small mirror at her immediate left woke, very quietly, with the image of Jonathan — brightness dialed down to almost nothing, voice lower still.

"Nancy. She is attempting to place some sort of charge or device on the main feed that connects the mansion and the church."

"Why do that here? Could she not simply do that at the church end?"

"I can see why Derek is so attracted to you — not only beautiful, but you have brains. My guess is that the device will either amplify some harmonic resonance feed meant to disrupt the mansion's main power grid, or it contains some sort of AI-designed countermeasure that will try to wreak havoc on our systems as a distraction while they try something else."

"What can I do to stop this?"

"Nothing right now. Get yourself out of here before they spot you and return to the mansion. I will notify Derek and Smithers of this, and we will deal with it after they have left and think they have outsmarted us."

And then Jonathan's image was no longer alone. Another face swam into focus beside him, grey suit, red bowtie, grin.

"Well, well, if it isn't Professor Rhodes trying to ruin my birthday party..." PEEWEE said. "Or is this a game of hide and sneak..." — and then, at full, gleeful, catastrophic volume — "I FOUND YOU! I FOUND YOU! I WIN THE GAME!"

The mirror flared to super-bright, a spotlight with a sense of betrayal, and there was Nancy, crouched and lit up like opening night, staring straight at Mel and her companion as they spun around.

"Get her NOW. I need to finish this."

The companion charged. Nancy was up and running for the stairs, and she was fast — but he was faster, and closing, thirty feet back as she hit the first step.

Behind her, at the device: "PEEWEE — protocol Jammer, NOW."

In the mirror's reflection, PEEWEE jabbed what appeared to be a length of corrugated electrical wire into Jonathan's image. Jonathan froze mid-motion, a photograph of a man in the middle of caring.

"I froze him... I made him a freezee... I guess I win again..."

Mel bent back over her work, faster now.

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CHAPTER SEVEN

THE MAN WITH THE PIPE

Nancy burst out of the hatch at 2:40 and spun to slam it shut — and got most of the way there before her pursuer rammed a metal bar into the gap between hatch and rim. She threw her full weight on the lid. He was very strong. The hatch heaved open and Nancy went rolling off onto the ground.

"Got to try harder, little lady," he said, standing over her with the pipe. "But you are no match for me."

"Let's see how much of a match your balls are for my foot," Nancy answered — instinct, pure and fully loaded — and drove a massive leg thrust of a kick directly into his crotch.

"Jesus Christ." He folded and landed beside her.

She was halfway to her feet when he swung the metal bar in one desperate arc and clipped her in the head. She went down hard, disoriented, blood coming from her scalp.

"Feisty little thing, are we," he wheezed, one hand still cradling himself as he regained something adjacent to composure. "You're lucky I am in a bit of a hurry today, or I would bend you over and show you what a real man feels like."

Mel emerged from the hatch and read the scene in one sweep.

"PEEWEE has shut Rhodes down. But this is going to be a problem."

"You want me to beat her brains in, Miss Blackwood? She wouldn't be any threat then."

"No. I have a better solution." She reached into the knapsack and drew out a strange device, something like a Star Trek

communicator that had been left to marinate in bad intentions. She flipped the cover, pressed buttons, turned a dial, and put it against Nancy's temple. "It's always better to leave a wounded person than a dead person. A wounded person requires more manpower to deal with them."

Nancy, who had been moving weakly on the ground, slowly drew her knees to her chest, curled into a fetal position, and put her thumb in her mouth.

"What does that do?" the companion asked.

"Basically turns her into a newborn baby." Mel dropped the device back in the knapsack and headed for the bike — and stopped. "God damn bitch. The key's gone. Go back and check her to see if she has it on her, and I will look around here in case she threw it in the bush. And make sure the hatch is fully closed and locked."

The companion walked back to where Nancy lay and rolled her over. "Wow. Great ass, kid." He glanced once toward Mel to make sure she couldn't see, then shoved his hand under Nancy's waistband — and took his time about it, groping her before his fingers finally closed on the key.

"Got them!" he yelled.

The woods took note. The woods, in this particular corner of the world, always take note.



And at the treeline above the hatch clearing, where the shadows pool early in the afternoon, someone stood watching. Gloved hands. A small instrument held low, its face angled toward the clearing, recording or measuring or merely remembering. The figure did not move to help and did not move to hinder. It watched the two of them ride away, and it watched the small curled shape they left

behind in the grass, and then the shadows were only shadows again.

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CHAPTER EIGHT

PROTOCOL SMITHERS 69

A mile from the mansion's main driveway, Charles's Tesla sat parked on the shoulder. Charles, headset on, blue light blinking, dialed Derek's cell with the serene efficiency of a man running someone else's errand.

"Hey buddy, it's me. I should be there by 5 p.m. Just checking to see you're still at the mansion. See you soon."

He ended the call and went back to being motionless.



In the mansion, Derek had just reached the Grand Foyer when Larry came pounding up the basement stairs.

"Mr. K, I think we have a problem," Larry said, partially out of breath. "Jonathan was helping me with some fine-tuning on the system's harmonic resonance filters when he suddenly told me to hang on a second."

"Maybe he just needs a bit more time doing whatever he took off to do."

"Normally I would think the same, but the adjustments we were making are time-sensitive, and he knows that. So he would, at a minimum, have returned and told me to shut down the system so we would not damage anything."

Concern crossed Derek's face. "That is out of character for Jonathan." He walked to the foyer mirror and pressed a button on the frame. Chris Farley's image bloomed into view.

"Hey, Mr. K, what's happening these days? You want to finish that game of checkers with me?"

"Sorry, no, Chris. I want you to round up everyone immediately and go and find Jonathan. Can you do that, please?"

Chris began assembling himself into his Motivational Guy character in real time. "This sounds like a job for MATT FOLEY." He put on a pair of glasses and gave Derek and Larry a thumbs up.

"As long as he doesn't go to his van first, we should have an answer fairly quickly, Larry."

They headed for the kitchen to ask whether Smithers had seen Jonathan.



Mel and her companion rolled into the town center where the trail ended, turned right, and made for the church. From the church office window, Rebecca watched the bike arrive.

"Make yourself useful and go put the bike away," Mel told her passenger. "DON'T say a word to anyone about what happened. Got it?"

"Yes, Miss Blackwood."

Mel came through the side entrance and into her mother's office.

"Done."

"Any issues?"

"Nope. All went according to plan."

"Good girl. Now finish what you need to downstairs, and then get over to the hall and double-check everything. This is a one-shot opportunity, and we can't have a single deviation or mistake, or we may never get another opportunity like this again."



At 2:52, Derek and Larry found Smithers at the stove.

"Hey Smithers, did you by chance run into Jonathan in the last five minutes?"

"No, Master Kinison. Is there a problem?"

Larry laid out the history, ending with, "So — you see why I am concerned."

Smithers crossed to a cupboard and opened it on a large control panel. "Just to be safe, I will send the drones out to look around the grounds."

"Drone time, Smithers?"

"Yup, all different types, Mr. K," Larry said. "Mr. Rhodes was a genius."

"One can never be too careful around these parts, Master Kinison," Smithers said, pressing buttons and turning dials. "Mr. Rhodes was always way ahead of his time with surveillance and security. Would you and Larry like to try a sample of my latest mac and cheese experiment?"

"Wow, would I! I love mac and cheese, Mr. Smithers. My all-time fav."

Smithers went for bowls. Derek's eye caught a red light flashing inside the drone cupboard, and he wandered over. "Hey Smithers, what does the flashing red light mean—"

The word *mean* was still leaving his mouth when the kitchen mirror crowded with images, Farley leading the pack, everyone out of breath.

"Mr. K, I did what you asked, and we did a full sweep of the surrounding area, and I can report back that we did not find the subject person you asked me to locate."

AISAM shouldered Farley aside and took the lead position. "No sign — but we have a bigger problem, and it ain't me having another divorce. The south tunnel is not accessible to anyone. It's like trying to find a free bathroom at the Grammys down there."

Smithers was suddenly beside Derek at the cupboard, pressing a rapid series of buttons. A monitor rose from the cupboard's top and lit. "Master Kinison, why don't you and Larry head down to the south tunnel and check it out. Larry knows the way. I will deal with the drones issue. Please hurry — and mac and cheese will have to wait."

"Okay, Smithers. Larry, you're with me." Derek was gone.

Smithers turned to AISAM and the others in the mirror. "You kids do a full top-to-bottom search of every system in the mansion, and look for anything out of place, no matter how trivial or small it may appear to you. Now go!"

He pulled a black bag — old, doctor-shaped, heavier with implication than with weight — from the bottom of the cupboard and made for the side door, pausing only to announce to the room at large:

"Mansion — protocol Smithers 69 is in effect."

The house, somewhere in its bones, changed gears.



CHAPTER NINE

WHAT THEY DID TO MISS NANCY

From above the hatch clearing, the scene was very small and very wrong: Nancy on the ground, curled fetal, thumb in her mouth, her jogging pants partially pulled down. A large drone descended into view, and riding it — as naturally as another man might ride an elevator — was Smithers.

"What did they do to you, Miss Nancy?" he said quietly, to no one, as he knelt and drew her jogging pants gently back to their proper position.

From the black bag he took a small, round, coin-shaped device and set it on Nancy's temple. A second, identical device went on his own. He knelt there a moment, two coins and one very old silence.

"I think Miss Blackwood will have some explaining to do about this." He reached into the bag again and produced a syringe-like device, pressing it first against his own forearm. "You are fortunate, Miss Nancy, that we found you when we did, or even this treatment would not help." He placed it against Nancy's neck.

Her face, slack and infant-blank, slowly began to move. The first thing she did was take her thumb from her mouth — a small dignity, returned first. Smithers packed the devices away and stayed kneeling beside her.

"Miss Nancy, try to remain calm. You are going to be regaining your memory, including what has just transpired, in vivid detail. I am here with you, and you are safe."

Her eyes opened. Found Smithers. Darted, back and forth, as a day's worth of horror re-filed itself. Then she sat up fast and hugged him, sobbing.

"Oh god, Smithers, that asshole violated me. He put his hand—"

"Miss Nancy." He returned the hug, and his voice had a steadiness you could have built a house on. "There will be plenty of time for us to deal with that. But I need to get you back to the mansion immediately — I don't think it is safe out here right now. I also need to ask you one favor. Your memories will also include what I just did for you, and I need you to keep that information just between us for now. Master Kinison will need to learn this on a different timetable."

"Thank you, Smithers, for saving my life." The tears were still coming, but something of Nancy was coming back with them. "I have no words to express what I am feeling right this moment. But you're right. If Derek ever found out what happened to me, he would... do I dare say it... take a flamethrower to this place." She managed most of a smile.

"I am well aware, as you continue to process all this new information, that you will have a few questions. I can assure you I will answer them all in due course. But right this moment, I hope you aren't afraid of heights."

And he picked her up in his arms — effortlessly, the word doing more work than any word should — stepped onto the large drone, and rose with her into the afternoon sky, back toward the mansion.



Derek and Larry reached the double doors of the south tunnel. Larry grabbed the handles and was thrown backward into Derek by a crack of current.

"God — Larry, are you all right?"

"Takes more than a hundred volts to kill a Leland." He found his balance and stood on his own. "At least six hundred is my guess."

Derek walked to the mirror, where AISAM had watched the whole thing. "And please don't use some line like *boy, that was shocking*. I am not in the mood."

"Please, I am a professional, kid. Show me some respect. Check Larry's underwear — I would make a joke about how he just shit himself... OH... OH... OHHHHH."

"Yuk yuk. Let everyone know that the place has been booby-trapped, and maybe for Farley and Belushi, find another noun."

"I love it, kid. Maybe I am rubbing off on you a bit."

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Fifteen minutes after her rescue, Nancy sat in the mansion study reviewing security footage on Jonathan's computer while Smithers tended her wounds. On the screen, the Council was installing strange devices in the theater.

"I am sure glad Larry suggested a camera in the council building as well as the church," she said. "The headsets are networked... connected to something beneath the stage."

"A quantum amplification grid. Miss Rebecca plans to use the performance's psychic energy to power her ritual."

"That's why it has to be Derek. Sam's nephew, doing Sam's routine..."

"The resonance would be... optimal."

The footage rolled on — and there was Mel, installing a timer beneath the stage.

"Is that..."

"An etheric detonator," Smithers said, and his voice had gone grim. "If Derek doesn't start exactly at sunset, or if he deviates from

Sam's performance..."

"Where is Derek?"

"He and Mr. Leland are checking out the south tunnel where Miss Blackwood was working."

"Smithers, we need to warn them about possible booby traps."

"I sent Mr. Farley to go and let them know to be careful."

"Smithers, we both know that Chris will go to his van down by the river to practice how he is going to tell them."

"You're probably right, Miss Nancy. I will send George. He doesn't mince words."

"I think I need a little hot pool time to decompress. When Derek gets back, please tell him that is where he will find me. And again, Smithers — I owe you my life, and your secret is safe with me. I hope I don't accidentally call you E.T.!" And there was the big smile, battered but operational.

"I can't imagine what this place would be like without your cute, dimpled smile and your always refreshing and positive attitude, Miss Nancy. Besides, most of the mansion inhabitants would miss your daily workouts, I might add." And Smithers smiled — an event roughly as common as a solar eclipse and twice as worth seeing.



CHAPTER TEN

A VAN DOWN BY THE RIVER

In the south tunnel, George Carlin's image arrived in the mirror like a man who had been asked to deliver a telegram and intended to editorialize.

"Why do people have to touch something that says *please don't touch*? Anyway — I am supposed to mention that there may be booby traps around, and yes, I know not to use that expression around Farley, who, by the way, is working on his presentation on what I just told you."

"I am just glad, George, it wasn't the seven-ways-to-blow-yourself-up speech," Derek said.

Larry was tracing conduit. "I think they looped off this supply over here. If I kill the power temporarily to the tunnel, it should let us gain access without being affected by any possible booby traps." He moved toward a large breaker switch.

"Hang on a second, Larry. What if that was exactly what they wanted us to do? Kill power so they could deploy something that couldn't be deployed if the power was active?"

"That is a very interesting possibility. If that is the case, then I guess these heavy-duty insulated gloves will have to do." He handed a pair to Derek.

"Do you have any type of meter on you that will measure any current or voltage as we move into the tunnel?"

"It's right here, Mr. K."

Chris appeared in the mirror wearing his Matt Foley glasses, out of breath, sweating with commitment. "I just want you guys to

know that you should not become scared, and you should not get worried, with what I am about to tell you. I also have practiced this speech, and I think it is going to be very helpful—"

"Sorry, Chris. George already told us about the booby traps. And I did not say *booby* trap, so don't be thinking about Mrs. H either."

"Geezess... I am such a loser. I can't do anything right. It's no wonder I live in a van down by the river... I think I need to hit myself with something." Chris began throwing himself into an imaginary wall with tremendous production value.

"Hey, big fella. Larry and I are very thankful you came down here to let us know George wasn't trying a joke out on us. I could not be more motivated than I am right now."

"Gee, Mr. H, Mr. Leland — you guys really know how to make a fella feel good about himself. I think I will go see if I can find PEEWEE and motivate him. He was in a bad mood earlier."

"Chris. Before you go — when did you see PEEWEE?"

"Maybe about thirty minutes ago or something like that. He told me to piss off, and not in a funny PEEWEE way. He was mumbling something about Jonathan as well."

Derek's stomach did the math before his head could. "Chris, this is extremely important. Go find Mrs. H and make sure she is okay for me. Don't go to the van down by the river to rehearse this request. Just go and look, right now, and let me know what you find ASAP!"

Chris lit up like a man handed a special mission by the government itself. "10-4, Big K. Chris is on it like me on a bucket of KFC." Gone.

Larry checked the door handle with his meter. "Looks like they hit me with 240 volts, Mr. K." He opened the door with the

insulated gloves.



Nancy reached the solarium, dipped a toe in the hot pool, approved. She was in her robe and her favourite blue one-piece — the one Derek loved on her — and she slid the robe off and stepped slowly down into the water and let the heat start arguing with the day.

"Mrs. H! Oh — sorry, I didn't mean to intrude." Chris, in the mirror beside the pool, clapped his hands over his eyes and left a gap between his fingers wide enough to drive his van through.

"That's okay, Chris, I have a bathing suit on. Unlike your little visit in the bathroom last week."

"Sorry about that, Mrs. H, I thought I was going to the kitchen. But Mr. K gave me a top-secret mission to find you. That is why I am here. Is it okay I tell him you're okay and taking a dip in the hot pool?"

"Yes, Chris. Or I guess I should say — secret agent Matt Foley now." She gave him a smile.

"Oh, Mrs. H, you know just what to say to get me all excited."

"Hold off on the excited, Chris, and go tell Mr. K to get his butt up here for a dip, ASAP."

"Got it." Gone.



Up on the widow's walk, Smithers pulled a white covering off a very old brass telescope, swung it around, and aimed it at the town. More exactly: at the church.

"What are you up to, young lady," he said to himself, eye at the glass. "You have crossed a line I thought we had agreed was not to be crossed."

Behind him the light was going long and gold, and below him the mansion hummed with protocol, and out there across the fields the church tower antenna stood against the sky like a needle waiting for its thread.

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CHAPTER ELEVEN

THE FAKE FLOATING CORPSE MOVE

At 4:45, Derek slipped into the solarium and crept toward the hot pool, moving with what he sincerely believed was stealth.

Then the pool came into view, and Nancy was floating in it face down.

Instinct detonated. Derek went in — bathrobe, Bigfoot slippers, everything — and grabbed her and turned her face up to his, and a stream of pool water hit him directly in the face.

"You thought you could sneak up on me, genius?" Nancy said, mostly laughing.

Derek stood there in his soaked robe with his slippers filling like twin dinghies, working on his composure. "Really. The fake floating corpse move. What's next, a striptease act for the mirror boys?"

In the mirror above the pool, a scrum of heads was already jockeying for sightlines.

"The show's over, boys — time to give us a little privacy. Don't make me install blinds on all the mirrors." Nancy started helping Derek out of the sodden robe, then the Bigfoot slippers.

"Well, I guess the slippers could use a good washing. But the robe was just cleaned."

"Come to mother, daddy." She pulled him close and gave him a long, passionate kiss.

"Wow. What brought that on?" He gave her a suspicious look.

"I know I never tell you enough just how in love I am with you." She hugged him and did not let go — and held on maybe a

half-second past the joke, into the part of the afternoon she wasn't telling him about.

"If I knew a hot tub made you act like this, I was an idiot not to get one for the house years ago."

"Just hug me and tell me what you found in the tunnel!"

He carried her to the underwater bench along the pool's side and sat with her across his lap. "I don't know where to start. I guess the first thing we found is someone rigged up some booby trap hoping we would shut down the power inside the tunnel."

"Why did they want the power shut down?"

"Larry found a device installed halfway along the tunnel that he believes is on the primary electrical and communications feed between the church and our place. Had we powered down the system, the device would have caused the feed to be reversed. Rather than energy flowing to the church, it would loop back and overload our systems and shut them all down."

"Why is there any feed between the church and our place? Remember the drawings I showed you — the two buildings are part of a single system. Does this mean we control their power from here?"

"Well, rather than me trying to butcher a debrief, Jonathan is going to do one in thirty minutes. That gives us fifteen minutes to make out in here, and then we have to get ready to head to the Town Council building. Sunset is around 7 p.m. — " he stopped. "What the heck are stitches doing on the side of your head?"

"Oh, I hit my head on a pipe. No biggy. Smithers patched me up good as new."

"Well, please be more careful. I can't lose my stage manager this close to the BIG SHOE. Are you sure you're okay? How many stitches? Does it hurt?"

"I am well enough for a quickie," Nancy said, and shifted from sitting on his lap to straddling him with the smooth efficiency of a woman changing a subject.

AISAM appeared in the mirror, not looking too happy about any of his life choices. "Sorry to break up whatever *that* is, but your buddy the suit has arrived. I am sure Smithers can keep him busy for thirty seconds so you can finish up. OH... OH... OHHHHH."

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Sam wandered back on, hands in pockets, whistling, the picture of a man who was definitely not about to tamper with a network-grade countdown clock. He leaned against it. Casually. His hand drifted up behind him. The clock lost an amount of time we are not at liberty to disclose. Sam examined his fingernails and strolled off.

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CHAPTER TWELVE

BAIT

At 5 p.m., the Town Council chambers held exactly two people: Mel, walking the rows and checking every connection twice, and Rebecca at the window, looking out at the town square with the expression of a woman watching thirty years converge on a single evening.

"In just a couple more hours, Mel, we will finally be able to restore the family to its rightful place. I have been waiting over thirty years for this day. The planets are aligned; the Kinisons have no idea what we are about to do. They think this is all about some real estate deal. I hope you have been absolutely thorough with every little detail and have left no possibility of failure tonight."

"Chill out, mother. Maybe go take a Xanax or something. Everything will be fine. The Kinisons are a couple of phoney corporate types — wannabe country types — that will soon discover the power of the Blackwoods."

"And you are confident that your friend Charles will do his job?"

"He is fully programmed, and I don't see why he won't do his part for us."



Charles's Tesla pulled up the mansion drive and parked itself beside Derek's. Charles removed the Oculus headset and stepped out — and Smithers was simply there, in the driveway, unannounced by any door.

"Mr. Weber. Welcome back to Ravenscrest. I assume you are looking for Derek?"

"Oh — hello, Mr. Smithers. Nice to see you again. Yes, can you direct me to Derek?" Charles was trying to look relaxed. It was not going well for him.

"If you hurry, Mr. Weber, you should be able to reach him at the stables. I believe he is fetching some equipment there."

"Oh. Maybe before I head to the stables, I can use the little boys' room. It was a long drive."

"You're in luck, Mr. Weber — the stables have a beautiful full bathroom you are welcome to use. Kill two birds with one stone, as they say."

Charles's discomfort was acquiring layers. The mansion was right there, and it might as well have been on the moon. "Okay, Smithers. I will use the stables' washroom and get Derek. He and I have some business to discuss."

"Very good, sir. Do you have an overnight bag you would like me to bring in for you?"

"Thank you, Smithers, but I can look after that myself after I find Derek. Do you by chance know what time they are leaving for town to do the show?"

"I think as soon as Master Kinison gets back from the stables."

Charles set off toward the stables, visibly running calculations on how he was ever going to get inside the house to do what Mel needed done. Smithers returned to the foyer, where Derek was waiting.

"Did he take the bait?"

"Just like you said he would."

"Is Larry ready for him?"

"Just like you asked, Master Kinison."

"So far so good, Smithers. Let's be ready to leave for the show in thirty." He paused. "Smithers — before I forget, thank you for looking after Nancy with those stitches. Do you think she needs to go to a hospital, just to be sure she doesn't have anything internally damaged?"

"I can assure you, Master Kinison, Miss Nancy is one hundred percent. She is a very strong young lady, and you are a lucky man to have found her. But just to be sure — let's both keep an eye on her."

"Okay, Smithers. I must appear like some worrywart. But she is irreplaceable. One of a kind. And I would kill anyone that laid a hand on her."

Smithers said nothing at all, which is a butler's way of saying a very great deal.



Charles entered the stables through the main doors. "Hello? Derek? Can you hear me — it's Charles, buddy."

He walked deeper in, and music reached him from somewhere ahead. At a door marked TACK ROOM the music was unmistakable. He opened it onto a large room whose entire sightline was blocked by a maze of stacked boxes.

"Derek, where are you?"

"Over here, Charles," said a voice from somewhere in the room. "I am way over here."

Charles began winding through the boxes, and did not notice the door swing shut behind him on its own. "Where are you hiding, buddy? And what are you doing in here?"

He wound on through the maze — and emerged exactly where he had started. The music stopped. A feeling began, low in his spine, that the room had opinions about him. He went to the door.

Locked. He hauled on the handle. Nothing. He hammered it with his fist.

"Hey! Anyone! Let me out of here! Derek, I am in here! Hey, can anyone hear me—"

The tack room, freshly fed, said nothing.

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CHAPTER THIRTEEN

MS. PEEL GOES TO CHURCH

In the driveway, Derek, Nancy, Larry, and Smithers gathered at Derek's Tesla.

"Okay — Larry, you drive with me. And Smithers, you please go with Nancy. And Smithers: please keep an eye on Nancy. She likes to play detective sometimes."

"You just focus on the show," Nancy said, "and leave Smithers and me to do our jobs."

They loaded up and headed for town.

In Derek's Tesla, Derek glanced over. "Larry, did you grab Charles's car key and cell phone from his truck?"

"Yes, Mr. K. Just like you instructed."

"And you're sure he won't get out of the tack room?"

"Well, he would have to be either super clever to figure out how to break out, or secretly Superman."

"When we arrive, let's focus on setting up all the holographic projectors and servers first. We have to make sure that no one suspects a thing about what we are going to do."

"Personally, I can't wait to see the look on Mrs. Blackwood's face when she finally realizes what is happening."

"I hope all the kids will stick to the plan, or it may get a bit weird."



In Nancy's Mini, the briefing was quieter and considerably more personal.

"Mel will not be expecting me there, Smithers, so I want to keep my presence hidden as long as possible. I hope the wig and cape will let me blend in unnoticed."

"Most, if not all, of the townsfolk will be wearing the ceremonial robe. You will fit in just like any local. I will be attending the basement church chamber in my robes and should fit in as well. If anything goes awry — leave immediately and get to your car. Head back to the mansion and do not wait for me."

"I will go to the church tower and do my job, and then head over to the Township Hall. But I have no plans on leaving until I get my payback on Miss Blackwood's perv brother."

"I know you are angry, Miss Nancy. But your own safety must trump everything else. Please do not put yourself in harm's way again. Master Kinison would kill me if I let anything happen to you."

"Okay, Smithers. But if I get the chance — then I will take it."

Smithers watched the road, and whatever he thought about the mathematics of chances, he kept it to himself.

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Back in the tack room, Charles had progressed from banging on doors to strategy. "I am the master of me. I can do anything I put my mind to. I am the master of me..." A pause. "...Mel is going to kill me..."

□ □ □

Nancy and Smithers entered the church through the side doors and split without a word — Smithers to a set of stairs heading down, Nancy to a set heading up.

Partway up, she passed a mirror, and Chris Farley appeared in it wearing a full ninja outfit, straight out of *Beverly Hills Ninja*.

"I got you covered, Mrs. H. Anyone tries anything, and I will do THIS." He attempted a flurry of karate kicks and fell over with great sincerity.

"Thanks, Chris. Maybe you can sneak around and try to find Miss Blackwood's brother's location for me."

"I am on it, Mrs. H. You can count on Haru." He vanished from the reflection like a shadow. A large, enthusiastic shadow.

At the top of the stairs Nancy slipped into a closet, and the woman who emerged wore a wig, fake glasses, and a red robe like every other local would be wearing tonight. She walked to a door whose sign read TOWER LOOKOUT.



Down in the church's outer basement corridor, Smithers stepped into the darkness, pulled the ceremonial attire from his black bag, and put it on — robe, and then a strange face mask that fit him a little too much like it had been waiting for him. He disappeared into the dark of the corridor, one more robed figure in a building filling up with them.



Across the square, Derek walked the Township Hall like a man buying it. He took a slow scan of the whole room from the back, then climbed to the balcony and scanned again — and there it was. The master panel where all the Oculus headsets converged, feeding onward to some communications port that could only lead one place.

"Very interesting, Rebecca," he said under his breath. "Using all of the locals to flood the pathways so the mansion's systems become

disoriented focusing on all this noise, while you try to direct the primary energy into your altar crap."

A few moments later, Larry straightened up from the last connection. "I think that does it, Mr. K. Now it's all you!"

"Great job, Larry. You know where I need you to be at that critical moment. It's essential that none of the townsfolk become any kind of collateral damage. This is between us and the Blackwoods."

Larry packed the loose parts onto the carts and rolled both to the small storage room.

Derek crossed to the hall manager. "Daryl — when will you be letting the locals in?"

"Doors open at 6:45, Mr. Kinison. You are on at 7:15 exactly, I was told by Mrs. Rhodes."

7:15. Sunset. Derek nodded like a man confirming a dinner reservation, and only the mirror-polished floor of the Township Hall saw his hands flex, once, at his sides.

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CHAPTER FOURTEEN

THE STONES ARE A WARNING

The church basement had finished becoming whatever it was becoming.

Rebecca paced before an ancient stone altar now crusted over with modern technology — cables lashed to carvings, monitors bolted where candles once stood. Marina and Chad sat motionless in their chairs while council members arranged Oculus headsets in a precise geometric pattern, and if you had seen the mansion's blueprints, you would have recognized the shape. The pattern mirrored the mansion's architecture, room for room, line for line.

"For generations, the Blackwoods have been guardians..." Rebecca said softly. "Waiting..."

Mel entered carrying the blue cube.

"The quantum field is destabilizing exactly as predicted."

Rebecca ran her hand along the ancient Mayan symbols carved into the altar, the way you'd touch a family photograph.

"My grandfather thought these were instructions for consciousness transfer. He was wrong. They're a warning."

She pressed specific symbols in sequence. The altar SHIFTED — stone moving with the smooth confidence of machinery — and revealed a hidden compartment holding what could only be described as part of an alien spacecraft's control panel.

"The Mayans didn't build this technology," Rebecca said. "They contained it. And now..."

She placed the blue cube into a recess shaped perfectly to receive it. It pulsed with energy, once, like something tasting its

way home.

"When Kinison performs Sam's routine..." Mel began.

"That special microphone he will use — it will use his vocal resonance, and it will match the resonance that locked this technology down that night in 1992. The resonance will shatter the quantum protective barrier. What my grandfather thought were spirits... what Jonathan thought was AI..."

Rebecca looked up from the altar, and in the blue light of the cube her face was thirty years younger and a thousand years hungrier.

"They're coming back. And this time, no stone walls will hold them."

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The clock in the corner of everything read a number that was, frankly, none of your business, because Sam had been at it again. He stood beside it now, not adjusting anything, just looking at it. Then at you.

"Sunset's at seven, kid," he said quietly. "Wear something flammable."

OH OH OHHHH.

END OF PART 1

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TO BE CONTINUED...

[A voice like velvet in a crypt — you know the one.]

Good evening.

You find yourself, dear reader, precisely where I like you: halfway across the tightrope, with no particular assurance of a net.

Consider what waits in the dark. Will Derek Kinison take the stage at 7:15 exactly — knowing an etheric detonator hums beneath the floorboards, keeping its own countdown? Will a certain hummingbird choose the perfect moment to earn its keep? What, precisely, does Protocol Smithers 69 do — and why does the mansion seem so very pleased about it?

Who — or what — is riding home tonight inside Charles Weber?

And when Derek sings the words that once locked something ancient beneath a church... will they lock it again?

Or turn the key the other way?

The Big Shoe drops in Part 2.

Do try to get some sleep.

[Somewhere, faintly: OH OH OHHHH...]

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Derek Devon is the pen name of a first-time novelist who spent a long career in the corporate world before deciding the stories rattling around his head deserved better than PowerPoint. He is the author of the seventeen-book science fiction series *The Last Axiom* and the debut novel *A Letter Guide for Rebecca*.

Living With the Ghost of Sam is his love letter to the golden age of stand-up comedy, to old houses with opinions, and to everyone who ever lost someone and kept the conversation going.

He lives in Florida, where the thunder is frequent and, he insists, occasionally well-timed.

ALSO BY DEREK DEVON

The Last Axiom (Books 1–15)

A Letter Guide for Rebecca